Pundarika Vidyanidhi

Пундарика Видьянидхи · @pundarika-vidyanidhi

The Treasury of Love

Among the associates of Sri Chaitanya there are few for whom the Lord Himself longed before He had even seen them, and whose name He could not utter without tears. Pundarika Vidyanidhi is one of them. “Vidyanidhi,” “treasury of learning,” is his title of honour: he knew all the shastras deeply. But the Lord, seeing in him a great premika, also called him Premanidhi, “the treasury of love.” According to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (56), Gaura Himself joyfully gave him this name, and it rings out in the Lord's words at their first meeting (CB, Madhya 7.143). Karnapura calls him “Vidyanidhi-mahashaya,” “the venerable Vidyanidhi,” and so does the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” which calls him a dear associate of Sri Chaitanya (Madhya 7.14); and he was an immeasurably dear devotee of Krishna[1].

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, describing the tree of Sri Chaitanya, calls Pundarika Vidyanidhi the third great branch of that tree and says that the Lord loved him so much that He wept when uttering his name (CC, Adi 10.14). He belongs to those elders whom Krishna, having resolved to descend, sent into the world before Himself — to the guru-varga:

“First He sent to the earth all His intimates and elders. I shall list them briefly — to describe them all in detail is simply impossible. Sri Shachi Devi and Jagannatha Mishra, Sri Madhavendra Puri, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Srivasa Pandita, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Adi 13.53–54)

Family and Homeland

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says that the Lord Himself ordained his appearance in Chattagrama, to bless those eastern lands (Madhya 7.10): “The great Vaishnavas Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Chaitanya-vallabha and Vasudeva Datta appeared in Chattagrama” (Adi 2.36–37). In his commentary on these verses Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes that Pundarika's father was Baneshvara (according to another opinion, Shuklambara) Brahmachari[2], his mother Ganga Devi, and his wife Ratnavati[3]; one of the biographies adds that the family bore the name Gangopadhyaya. Baneshvara was a Varendra brahmana; according to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, he settled in Baghiya, a village of Dacca district, and the local community of brahmanas did not accept him. The “Prema-vilasa” (vilasa 22), as one of the biographies quotes it, says that it was a highly respected family. It says too that Pundarika was a very wealthy zamindar with lands in Chakrashala, yet remained spotlessly pure in conduct; that he lived now in Chittagong, now in Navadvipa; and that he was a disciple of Madhavendra Puri.

He was born, according to one of the biographies, in Chakrashala, in the region of Chittagong, on the day of Vasanta-panchami — the fifth day of the bright fortnight of the month of Magha. Our calendar (Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math) also marks this day: in the month of Madhava, on Sri Krishna Vasanta-panchami, the appearance day of Srila Pundarika Vidyanidhi is celebrated. The sources do not give the year of his birth.

His ancestral home, his shripat, stood in the village of Meghala (Mekhala) in the police district of Hathazari in the district of Chattagrama, north of Chittagong itself; ten kroshas from there lies Chhanhara, the birthplace of Vasudeva Datta[4]. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes that his bhajana-kutir there has fallen into decay, and that no one can any longer read the ancient inscriptions on its wall and on a neighbouring temple; the descendants of the family relate that Mukunda Datta often came there to perform bhajana. The family was always small: generation after generation only one son was born in it,

and sometimes none; the descendants, who followed the shakta-dharma, became priests for those whom the community had rejected. One of them, Sarojananda Gosvami, lived in Vrindavana. But Pundarika also had a second home — on the bank of the Ganga, in Sri Mayapur, in Navadvipa; the Lord Himself speaks of it: “He lives in Chattagrama, but here in Mayapur he also has a house” (CB, Madhya 7.30).

Chittagong was the homeland of other associates of the Lord as well — Mukunda Datta, Vasudeva Datta and Gadadhara Pandita. Gadadhara's father, Madhava Mishra, was a good friend of Pundarika. Mukunda had long known him as a Vaishnava, whereas Gadadhara, although from the same parts, did not know him; one of the biographies explains that this was only an appearance, needed for the lila.

Disciple of Madhavendra Puri

Pundarika Vidyanidhi was a disciple of Sri Madhavendra Puri. According to one of the biographies, he received initiation from Madhavendra at the same time as Advaita Acharya. Karnapura writes that Gaura always showed him honour because he was Madhavendra's disciple (GGD 56). The Lord, playing the part of Ishvara Puri's disciple, honoured in Pundarika a godbrother of His own guru — for Ishvara Puri too was a disciple of Madhavendra.

Through Pundarika also runs the succession linking Madhavendra Puri with later Vaishnavas. One of the biographies, refuting the invention of the book “Chaurasi Baithak ke Charitra” that Madhavendra was initiated by Vitthalanatha, gives the true chain: the guru of Vallabhacharya was Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami, his guru Pundarika Vidyanidhi, and Pundarika's guru Madhavendra Puri.

“Pundarika, My Father!”

When Mahaprabhu in Navadvipa was revealing the majesty of His Vaikuntha pastimes, He missed one devotee, and He sighed heavily at not seeing Vidyanidhi (CB, Madhya 7.11). The Lord, the Inner Controller, knew that Pundarika wanted to dwell by the Ganga, and one day, having finished dancing, He sat down among the devotees and wept aloud:

“‘O Pundarika, My father, My friend! When shall I see you again?!’” (CB, Madhya 7.13)

At times, too, when in a swoon He briefly revealed His divine majesty, the Lord would utter the name “Pundarika Vidyanidhi” and call him “father.”

The devotees did not understand for whom He was weeping. “Pundarika,” “lotus,” is one of Krishna's names, but none of them knew the name “Vidyanidhi”; and they decided that the Lord was calling some Vaishnava very dear to Him (CB, Madhya 7.15–17). Recovering from their amazement, they asked: for which devotee is this weeping? The Lord replied: “You are fortunate that you wish to hear of him. Wonderful is all that he does; his very name purifies the world” (CB, Madhya 7.20–21).

And the Lord revealed to them Vidyanidhi's secret. In this hidden avatara of His — the prachchhanna-avatara — Gaura conceals Himself; and so Vidyanidhi conceals himself. He behaves like a man of the world, amid every appurtenance of a wealthy life, and no one recognises a Vaishnava in him: thus he deceives the fools who are misled by outward appearance. But within, he is ever immersed in the ocean of love for Krishna:

“He is always immersed in the ocean of love for Krishna. His body is adorned with such signs of divine love as trembling, tears and hair standing on end.” (CB, Madhya 7.24)

Students honoured him as a pandita, and pious people regarded him as the most righteous of men and learned dharma from him (CB, Madhya 7.22–23).

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati explains this passage in the “Gaudiya-bhashya.” A Vaishnava cannot be recognised by a superficial glance, just as Krishna's lila cannot be grasped by the limited senses. Some

take Krishna for an ordinary man and His deeds for those of a worldly hero; so too Krishna's servants sometimes remain unrecognised amid apparently worldly surroundings, hiding from the unworthy and pretending to be ordinary people. Gauranga Himself is the prachchhanna-avatara, and Pundarika in His pastimes played the part of a lover of pleasure before those whom appearances deceive. Not for nothing does a Bengali couplet, quoted by one of the biographies, say that “even the gods cannot recognise a Vaishnava.” Only one who has received the mercy of the Vaishnavas can understand who a Vaishnava is. And a Vaishnava is always free from the worldly (nirvishayi), whatever his clothes may be; only the unfortunate, looking at them, lose faith in the Vaishnava guru.

The Lord also told of Vidyanidhi's extraordinary reverence for the Ganga. He did not bathe in her, fearing to touch her with his feet — that would have been disrespect. He came to look at the Ganga only at night, unseen by people and from afar, for it pained him to see how she was offended: people rinsed their mouths in her water, cleaned their teeth, washed and dressed their hair. And before beginning the worship of the Deity he would drink Ganga water (CB, Madhya 7.25–29); thus by his example he taught many who wish to learn the proper order of worshipping the Lord.

“He lives in Chattagrama, but here too he has a house,” said the Lord. “Soon he will come here, but you will not recognise him: seeing him, you will take him for a mere man of the world. And without him I have no peace” (CB, Madhya 7.30–32).

A Secret Arrival

In those years scholars from all over Gauda gathered in Navadvipa and opened their chatushpathis there — Sanskrit schools. Drawn by the Lord, Pundarika too came from Chattagrama: he settled in his house in Sridhama Mayapur, by the Ganga, in such a way that hardly anyone knew of it. He came with servants, brahmanas and disciples, with a multitude of costly things, and behaved like a wealthy man of the world (CB, Madhya 7.36–38).

No one could truly come close to him, and many mistakenly took him for a “bhogi,” an enjoyer, and a “vishayi,” a man of the world. He concealed the depth of his devotion so skilfully that none of the Vaishnavas in Navadvipa recognised him. Only two knew him — his fellow countryman from Chattagrama Mukunda Datta, a teacher from a vaidya family (vaidya-upadhyaya), and Vasudeva Datta: they knew the glory of his deep service in love (CB, Madhya 7.39–43). It was Mukunda who told the Lord that Vidyanidhi had come, and Mahaprabhu rejoiced, but for the time being said nothing of it to any of the Vaishnavas.

Gadadhara

Mukunda dearly loved Gadadhara and shared with him everything he learned. “Today a wonderful Vaishnava has come to our town,” he said one day. “Would you like me to show him to you? Only, as my reward, remember me as your servant” (CB, Madhya 7.44–47). According to one account, Gadadhara, one of the Lord's closest associates, was himself fired with the desire to see the one for whom the Lord was longing so, and asked Mukunda to take him. Delighted, he set off at once with his friend, and on the way they chanted the names of Krishna.

Gadadhara bowed to Pundarika; Pundarika respectfully seated his guest and asked Mukunda who he was: “I see how his form shines with devotion to Vishnu” (CB, Madhya 7.50–52). Hearing that this was Gadadhara, the son of Madhava Mishra, detached from the world since childhood and loved by all the Vaishnavas, Vidyanidhi was overjoyed and spoke to him warmly[5].

But Gadadhara was looking around. Pundarika sat like a prince on a high couch beneath a canopy, amid silk whiter than milk foam and soft cushions. Beside him stood five or seven large and small jharis,

water jugs, and an elegant brass bowl of pan; he himself was chewing pan. Two servants at his sides fanned him with peacock-feather fans. His forehead was adorned with urdhva-pundra and a red dot of fragrant abir, his hair was artfully dressed, and he himself, by the power of bhakti, was as beautiful as Madana. Before him stood an ornate palanquin, a dola, with a bed inside; incense smouldered all around and servants thronged (CB, Madhya 7.57–66)[6]. He seemed a wealthy dandy — and such he wished to seem to those who judge by appearances.

From his very childhood Gadadhara had known no attraction to the worldly, and a doubt stirred in him: “Can he really be a Vaishnava? He eats choice food, wears costly clothes, his hair is dressed — just like a rich man of the world” (CB, Madhya 7.67–69). But this doubt too is part of the lila. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” at once adds that by Krishna's mercy nothing was beyond Gadadhara's understanding, for Krishna is the master of maya (Madhya 7.72); it was He who let His associate doubt for a moment, in order to reveal Vidyanidhi's glory to the world.

Mukunda understood what was happening in his friend's heart and, wishing to reveal who Vidyanidhi was, sweetly began to sing of the glory of bhakti: Putana came to poison the infant Krishna, yet He gave her the position of His mother — who, then, will not worship so merciful a Lord? And he recited two verses of the “Bhagavatam” on the same theme (3.2.23 and 10.6.35)[7]:

“Is it possible to find a more merciful protector than He who gave the position of His mother to the treacherous sister of Bakasura, although she offered Him her breast smeared with deadly poison?” (CB, Madhya 7.76; Bhag. 3.2.23)

As soon as Vidyanidhi heard these verses about bhakti-yoga, bliss flooded him. With a cry of “Ha Krishna!” he burst into sobs; tears gushed from his eyes like the Ganga descending to earth, and all eight sattvika-bhavas appeared in him at once — without the slightest pretence. “Go on! Say more!” he cried, and then he fell from the couch and rolled on the ground. With his feet he scattered and smashed to pieces all the costly utensils — the jugs, the bowl of pan; he tore his silk garments and dishevelled his dressed hair; ten men could not hold him, and the servants rushed to save whatever was still intact. “O Krishna, my Lord, my life!” he wept. “My heart has become like wood and stone! I alone have received nothing from so merciful an incarnation!” He lamented bitterly that he had not become a vessel of the mercy of so compassionate a Lord, and at last he lost consciousness, immersed in an ocean of bliss (CB, Madhya 7.78–93). Thus the true nature of his “luxury” was revealed: under the onrush of prema all that surrounded him flew apart in a single moment.

Vidyanidhi returned to outer consciousness only after two praharas — six hours (CB, Madhya 7.108). Gadadhara, amazed, embraced Mukunda in tears: “You are my true friend — you have shown me the greatest of devotees! And I took a mahabhagavata for an ordinary lover of pleasure and offended him. I shall receive mantra from him — and he will forgive me” (CB, Madhya 7.96–105); Gadadhara called the great devotee “Vidyanidhi Bhattacharya” (7.97). Vidyanidhi, coming to himself, was glad to see Gadadhara's tears, embraced him and pressed him to his heart (7.110), and Mukunda conveyed his friend's wish to him: “He is detached from the world and since childhood has never left the Lord; you two will be a worthy guru and disciple — fix an auspicious day” (7.111–116).

Pundarika smiled and was overjoyed: “Providence has brought me together with a great jewel. Such a disciple is obtained only by the good fortune of many births. I shall certainly give him initiation — on the coming dvadashi of the bright fortnight, at the most auspicious hour” (CB, Madhya 7.117–120). That day Gadadhara took leave of Mukunda and came to the Lord, and Vishvambhara, hearing of Vidyanidhi's arrival, was filled with boundless joy (CB, Madhya 7.121–122).

Meeting the Lord

One night Vidyanidhi came secretly to the Lord. He left all his servants behind and came quite alone, unseen by people on the road[8]. As soon as he saw Mahaprabhu, he fell unconscious from excess of joy, without even managing to bow down (CB, Madhya 7.123–125). Coming to himself, he gave a thunderous roar — a hunkara — and wept, reproaching himself that he alone in all the world had been left without the Lord's mercy; seeing him, all the Vaishnavas wept (CB, Madhya 7.126–129).

The Lord, Who Himself longed to see him, rose respectfully and embraced him:

“The Lord wept and exclaimed: ‘O Pundarika, My father. Today at last I have met My father.’” (CB, Madhya 7.131)

He pressed Vidyanidhi to His breast and bathed him in tears of love, and Vidyanidhi embraced the Lord so that the two bodies could not be told apart: it seemed as if the Lord had melted into the body of His devotee (CB, Madhya 7.134–136). For a whole prahara Gaurachandra remained motionless, and coming to Himself, He cried: “Hari! Hari!” Hearing how the Lord, weeping, called him “father” and “treasury of love,” the devotees understood how dear Vidyanidhi was to Him, and surrounded him with love and honour (CB, Madhya 7.135, 137).

The Lord brought him together with all the Vaishnavas, and all sang kirtana with Pundarika. “His title is Pundarika Vidyanidhi,” said the Lord. “The Creator made him to distribute prema-bhakti” — and, raising His arms, He cried aloud: “Hari!” (CB, Madhya 7.139–141).

“Today My morning is auspicious,” said the Lord. “I must have woken at a blessed moment: with My own eyes I have seen Premanidhi!” (CB, Madhya 7.142–143) Then Premanidhi returned to outer consciousness, recognised the Lord and bowed down to Him, and then to Advaita and to all the Vaishnavas, to each according to his greatness; the devotees looked at him and saw in him an ocean of prema (CB, Madhya 7.144–147).

After this meeting Gadadhara asked the Lord's permission to receive mantra from Pundarika: “Not knowing his unfathomable ways, I thought of him with disrespect; therefore I shall become his disciple — a guru surely forgives the offence of his disciple.” The Lord, pleased with his words, said: “Quickly, quickly!”[9] (CB, Madhya 7.148–151)

On the appointed auspicious day Gadadhara joyfully received initiation into mantra from Premanidhi (CB, Madhya 7.152). Thus two associates dear to Sri Krishna Chaitanya became for each other a worthy guru and a worthy disciple: Gadadhara displayed the lila of choosing his guru. “What more can I say of Pundarika's glory, when his disciple is Gadadhara? This is the summit for a devotee,” exclaims Vrindavana Dasa Thakura; he confesses that he longs one day to see Vidyanidhi, and promises that whoever reads and hears of the meeting of Pundarika and Gadadhara will gain the treasure of prema (CB, Madhya 7.153–156). The secret of their bond lies in Krishna's lila: according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” Pundarika is Vrishabhanu, the father of Srimati Radhika, and Gadadhara is Radha Herself; therefore the love of their former kinship was manifested between guru and disciple.

One of the biographies sees in this lila a lesson addressed to all who cannot tell a devotee from a non-devotee: it was revealed to put them to shame. Such people, the author adds, do not understand even the meaning of the honorary Vaishnava titles that were conferred by the Sri Navadvipa-dhama-pracharini Sabha and the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha.

In the Kirtanas of Navadvipa

From then on Pundarika attended the Lord's kirtanas in the house of Srivasa every night. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” listing the few intimate associates admitted to these night kirtanas at Srivasa's house and sometimes at Chandrashekhara's, names Nityananda, Gadadhara, Advaita, Srivasa,

Vidyanidhi, Murari, Hiranya, Haridasa, Gangadasa and others (Madhya 8.111–116). Kavi Karnapura writes in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya” that day after day the Lord danced ecstatically to the singing of His dear associates — now in Srivasa's house, now at Acharyaratna's, now “in the dwelling of Sri Vidyanidhi,” now in Murari's house (Act 2, v. 17); and when the Lord presented His drama in Acharyaratna's house, He Himself appointed as singers Srirama and others, and also Acharyaratna and Vidyanidhi (Act 3).

He was present too on the day of the Mahaprakasha, when for seven praharas — the “sat-prahariya bhava” — the Lord openly, concealing nothing, poured out His mercy on all His associates.

When the Lord had delivered Jagai and Madhai and was singing kirtana with them behind the closed doors of His house, Pundarika was among the few who were there:

“Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Haridasa Thakura, Garuda, Ramai, Srinivasa, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara Pandita and Chandrashekhara Acharya were well acquainted with the pastimes of Lord Chaitanya.” (CB, Madhya 13.239–240)

Seeing how the delivered brothers sat among the devotees showing the signs of prema, and what good fortune had befallen them, Pundarika was wholly absorbed in ecstasy. And afterwards the Lord went with all His associates to the Ganga and sported in her waters; Vidyanidhi was there too (CB, Madhya 13.336–339).

According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” as one of the biographies quotes it, Mahaprabhu celebrated the appearance day of Srimati Radharani in the house of Pundarika Vidyanidhi[10]. Thus in Navadvipa Radhashtami was kept in the house of Vrishabhanu.

When the Lord left Navadvipa and accepted sannyasa, Vidyanidhi, like all His associates, was in separation from Him. Karnapura puts this plea into his mouth: “O love, obeisance to you — for nowhere are you born without pretence! Even towards Him Whose mercy is free of pretence you are false — otherwise how could I still remain alive?” (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” Act 4, v. 29). And when the Lord came to Shantipur, Vidyanidhi was among the devotees who gathered to Him at Advaita's house:

“Srivasa, Ramai, Vidyanidhi, Gadadhara, Gangadasa, Vakreshvara, Murari and Shuklambara were there.” (CC, Madhya 3.153)

In Nilachala

When the Lord settled in Puri, the Vaishnavas of Gauda came to Him every year and stayed there for four months; Vidyanidhi was among them:

“The other devotees, headed by Advaita, Nityananda, Vidyanidhi, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and Srivasa, came to Sri Chaitanya every year and stayed in Nilachala for four months. With them Sri Chaitanya enjoyed a multitude of His beautiful pastimes.” (CC, Madhya 1.255)[11]

One of the biographies remarks that Krishnadasa Kaviraja names him among the leaders of the pilgrims. And listing those who set out from Gauda for Nilachala in the third year, the “Charitamrita” says:

“Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi, Srivasa, Ramai, Vasudeva, Murari Gupta, Raghava Pandita and Govinda with his two brothers set out on the road with their travelling bags.” (CC, Madhya 16.16)

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” listing the travellers, says: “Pundarika Vidyanidhi too went with them in great joy. Remembering him, the Lord wept aloud” (Antya 8.10); Murari Gupta also names him among them (“Pundarika Vidyanidhi, the treasury of love,” 4.17.3), and so does the “Charitamrita” (Antya 12.13). When the Bengalis first came to Puri, Gopinatha Acharya, pointing them out from the palace roof to King Prataparudra, named “Vidyanidhi Acharya” too (CC, Madhya 11.84; so also in the

“Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” Act 8), and the Lord embraced and glorified each of those who had come — Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi, Gadadhara and others (CC, Madhya 11.159–160).

In Puri he cleaned the Gundicha temple together with the Lord and the devotees and honoured maha-prasada with them[12].

Pundarika's closest friend in Nilachala was Svarupa Damodara. Their friendship began earlier still, when Svarupa bore the name Purushottama Acharya (CB, Antya 10.52). Svarupa felt for him the love of friendship, sakhya-priti; coming to Nilachala, Vidyanidhi lived together with him, and the two friends delighted in talks about Krishna, opening their hearts to each other without reserve (CB, Antya 10.101–102). Every day at dawn they went together for darshana of Jagannatha (CB, Antya 10.159).

When the Lord with all the devotees sported in the waters of Lake Narendra, the friends were together there too:

“The two friends, Pundarika Vidyanidhi and Svarupa Damodara, smiled as in ecstasy they splashed water on each other.” (CB, Antya 8.124)[13]

And in the days at Gundicha after the Ratha-yatra, when the Lord held water pastimes in Lake Indradyumna and the devotees contended in pairs, Vidyanidhi met Svarupa Damodara in the water (CC, Madhya 14.75–80).

The Mantra Received Again

Many years later, in Puri, the bond of guru and disciple was revealed once more. One day Gadadhara Pandita came to Sri Chaitanya and said: “Since I spoke my ishta-mantra to someone, my mind cannot clearly receive it. Repeat it to me again, and my mind will be at peace.” The Lord replied: “You have a guru who gave you the mantra; be careful, do not become an offender. What is a mantra? I would give you even My life; but while your guru lives, it is not fitting for Me to do this.” “He is not here,” Gadadhara objected; “act for him.” “Providence will easily bring you together with your guru Vidyanidhi,” said the Lord. “Not ten days will pass before he is here” (CB, Antya 10.22–30).

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains in his commentary on this passage (Antya 10.24): mantra is shabda-brahma, divine sound, received in order to give up thoughts of enjoyment. If one instructs in it a person without faith, impurity enters the mind of the instructor; and if divine knowledge has been lost through bad association, it must be obtained anew. Knowing this, Gadadhara asked the Lord for a new initiation. But Gadadhara himself, an eternal associate of the Lord, could neither lose the power of the mantra nor be defiled: his words are humility and an example for sadhakas. Through him the Lord teaches both instructors and disciples: a mantra passed on to an unworthy person must be heard again from one's own guru and not from anyone else — and indeed the Lord Himself would not repeat it in the guru's place.

And so it happened. One day the Lord, absorbed in bhakti-rasa, felt within Himself that Vidyanidhi had come: no sooner had He thought of him than Vidyanidhi appeared before Him. The Lord, smiling, exclaimed: “Father has come! Father has come!” Premanidhi was beside himself with prema; the Lord pressed him to His breast and wept, all the Vaishnavas around wept, and their love for Premanidhi kept growing (CB, Antya 10.67–73). There, before the Lord, he met his old friend Svarupa: each tried to take the dust of the other's feet, they pulled and pushed each other, and neither could prevail, while Gauranga watched them and laughed (CB, Antya 10.74–76). The Lord asked him to stay for a while in Nilachala, and he, counting it a great fortune, remained near the Lord; the Lord gave him lodging at Yameshvara, on the shore of the ocean (CB, Antya 10.77–78, 85). Gadadhara went to his guru and asked him to give him the ishta-mantra again, and he lovingly gave it (CB, Antya 10.79; CC, Madhya 16.78). Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, having told of this, exclaims: “What more can be said of the glory of Premanidhi, whose

disciple is Gadadhara, the very limit of divine love?" (CB, Antya 10.80).

His glory was sung by Advaita, Srivasa, Murari and Haridasa, and there was no Vaishnava who did not glorify him; he himself served all the devotees with body, speech and mind, and there was not a grain of pride in him. The rest of the story, Vrindavana Dasa says, he wrote down from the lips of Gadadhara himself (CB, Antya 10.81–84).

Odana-shashthi

In the year when Vidyanidhi stayed on in Puri, he saw the festival of Odana-shashthi (CC, Madhya 16.76–78). Gaurasundara with all the devotees also went to see Jagannatha being dressed: He Himself is both the worshipper and the One worshipped (CB, Antya 10.90–95). On this day, at the onset of winter, Jagannatha is dressed for the first time in winter garments; the cloth for them is new, not yet washed, and still contains weaver's starch — mar ("manduya"), according to one of the biographies made from tapioca. It is the pujaris who dress the Lord. And according to the smriti, starched cloth is considered impure. But the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" says: "As He wishes, so His servants act" (Antya 10.89).

Pundarika was a strict guardian of purity and Vaishnava etiquette, and he spoke of this with his friend Svarupa Damodara: "Why have they put unwashed cloth on the Lord? Everyone here knows both shruti and smriti." Svarupa replied that the Lord is above all rules and that there is no fault in this custom. "For the Lord Himself, yes," Pundarika persisted. "The Deity, Sri Vigraha, is chinmaya, spiritual; judgements about the gunas do not apply to Him. But have His servants too become Brahman? After touching starched cloth one washes one's hands — why, then, do the pujaris clothe the Lord in cloth that has not been washed?" So the two friends walked along the road hand in hand, laughing and arguing whether there was any fault in the conduct of Jagannatha's servants (CB, Antya 10.103–120).

This argument should not be understood as an argument about the rightness of the smriti. The "Chaitanya-bhagavata" itself reveals what took place: "Sometimes Krishna leads His servant into error, and then, out of compassion, dispels it" — and the Lord Himself led Vidyanidhi into error in order afterwards to dispel it (Antya 10.122–123). Pundarika is a great devotee, a dear associate of Mahaprabhu, and no fault lies on him: he only enacted the search for a fault in Jagannatha's devotees, and the Lord, Who loves His devotees, enacted another lila — to dispel this seeming error. The starched cloth is a service that the Lord accepts, and the lesson of this lila is addressed to us: we have no right to judge or to look for faults in the conduct of Jagannatha's devotees. Especially inclined to this are the smartas, who condemn Vaishnavas for not observing the rules of the smriti.

That same night the all-knowing Lord Chaitanya came to Vidyanidhi in a dream in the form of Jagannatha. Pundarika saw Jagannatha and Balarama; Jagannatha, displaying anger, seized him, and the two brothers began to slap him on both cheeks, so that the marks of Their fingers remained on them. "Krishna, save me! Forgive my offence!" Vidyanidhi pleaded. "Why are You beating me?" he asked Kanai and Balai. The Lord replied: "Your offences are endless. I have no caste, nor have My servants; living here, you ought to know this. If you fear losing caste, why do you stay where it is lost? I Myself established this festival, yet you, accepting Me as Brahman, see a fault in My servants who dress Me in starched cloth. If you wish to keep both the purity of bhakti and the customs of your class, leave Sri Kshetra and keep them at home" (CB, Antya 10.126–135). All these "faults" are seen only by the external eye.

The "Charitamrita" tells of this briefly:

"That night Jagannatha and Balarama came to him in a dream and, smiling, slapped him on the cheeks. Although his cheeks were swollen, Pundarika Vidyanidhi rejoiced in the depths of his heart. All this has already been described in detail by Vrindavana Dasa Thakura." (CC, Madhya 16.80–81)

Vidyanidhi in fear laid his head at the Lord's feet and wept: “Forgive all the offences of this sinner! You have punished the mouth with which I laughed at Your servants — and You did well. Today is a happy morning: Your hands have touched my cheeks.” “I punished you because I see in you My servant — out of mercy to you,” the Lord replied (CB, Antya 10.136–140). Waking and remembering the pain, Pundarika understood that the touch of the Lord's hands had brought him the greatest good fortune: the Lord Himself had punished him, and in this was his highest bliss, the true mercy of the master to the servant. His cheeks were swollen, yet he laughed: “Very good! The Lord is merciful — for my offence I got off lightly” (CB, Antya 10.142–144). When, next morning, the devotees noticed the traces of the blows on his cheeks, they laughed too.

Every morning Svarupa would call for his friend so that they could go together for darshana of Jagannatha. That day Vidyanidhi did not get up from his bed. He called Svarupa inside and, smiling, told him why his cheeks were swollen: “Last night all my doubts were dispelled. For two dandas Jagannatha and Balarama struck my cheeks, saying: ‘You have censured the cloth We wear.’ I am ashamed to show myself until my cheeks are healed; this should not be told to others. A great fortune has befallen me: had I not received fitting punishment, I would have fallen into a blind well” (CB, Antya 10.159–172). Svarupa, seeing the Lord's mercy to his friend, rejoiced: a true friend always rejoices in his friend's good fortune.

“Damodara Svarupa said: ‘Listen, brother. I have never seen such a wonderful punishment, nor heard of anything like it. The Lord came to you in a dream and punished you Himself.’” (CB, Antya 10.175–176)

Both laughed, floated in contentment and, not noticing how the days and nights passed, spoke only of Krishna (CB, Antya 10.173–177).

This story shows how dear Pundarika is to Krishna and Baladeva. To non-devotees the Lord is indifferent: He neither rewards nor punishes them. But a dear devotee, wishing his good, He Himself purifies — by punishment in a dream and in other ways — and personally punishes thus only His very closest. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” itself says: if a man in a dream receives punishment or wealth, all vanishes on waking, but the Lord's punishment and mercy in a dream are visible to all (Antya 10.149–150). There is no one in the world more fortunate than Vidyanidhi, adds Vrindavana Dasa: not even His son Pradyumna did the Lord teach in this way, and with non-devotees He does not speak even in a dream (Antya 10.145–151).

True Renunciation

The appearance of a rich man that Pundarika wore is neither a flaw nor a concession to the world, but a veil with which he concealed his prema. One of the biographies, speaking of renunciation, places him in one row with Ramananda Raya, Bhaktivinoda Thakura, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, the six Gosvamis, Lokanatha Gosvami and Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji: true vairagya is one and the same in all of them — the summit of the thirst to serve Krishna's pastimes — although some of them outwardly lived in wealth and others in utter renunciation. To non-devotees only a crude giving up of things looks like renunciation; but renunciation is measured not by poverty but by the thirst for service to Krishna, and Pundarika's outward wealth in no way distinguishes his vairagya from the vairagya of the Gosvamis.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes of this in his commentaries on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”: when materialists see the prosperity of such exalted Vaishnavas as Pundarika Vidyanidhi or Ramananda Raya, it only bewilders them the more — from the blindness born of intoxication with the senses (on Madhya 16.148). The perfect qualities of Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Ramananda Raya and Nityananda Prabhu any intelligent person will see and understand, while the unfortunate, searching for materialism in

Vaishnavas, only heap up offences; and to imitate the outward guise of a paramahamsa without those qualities is ruinous (on Antya 6.18).

Vrishabhanu

Kavi Karnapura reveals who Pundarika was in Krishna's lila:

“He who was once famous in the land of Vraja as Vrishabhanu is now the venerable Pundarika Vidyanidhi. Tasting His own mood and afflicted by separation like Radha, Chaitanya Himself called Pundarika ‘Father.’ Gaura joyfully gave him the glorious name Premanidhi, and always honoured him, because he was a disciple of Madhavendra. A special manifestation of him is considered to be Sri Madhava Mishra, and his wife Ratnavati is declared by the wise to be Kirtida.” (GGD 54–57)

King Vrishabhanu is the father of Srimati Radharani, and Mahaprabhu is Krishna Himself, Who has accepted the mood and radiance of Radha. Karnapura's words allow two readings: the Lord called Pundarika “father” when afflicted by separation like Radha — or when afflicted by separation from Radha, in His own, Krishna's, mood; so Srila Bhaktisiddhanta renders this verse. And the Lord called him so with tears: “Bap Pundarika!” — “Father Pundarika!”[14] Gadadhara, Pundarika's disciple, is Radha Herself; that is why the love of guru and disciple was the love of father and daughter. According to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” a special manifestation of Vrishabhanu is also Madhava Mishra, Gadadhara's father, and Ratnavati is Kirtida, Radha's mother.

Significance

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” concludes its account of him thus:

“Such is the greatness of Pundarika Vidyanidhi. Lord Gaurachandra called him father.” (CB, Antya 10.178)

And recalling that he did not enter the Ganga, fearing to touch her with his feet, but only looked at her and drank her water, and that the Lord always wept when calling him, “O father, Pundarika!”, Vrindavana Dasa Thakura promises: whoever hears of the life of Pundarika Vidyanidhi will surely attain the lotus feet of Krishna (CB, Antya 10.179–181)[15]. Vrindavana Dasa more than once glorifies Gaura as “the life and wealth of Pundarika Vidyanidhi” (Madhya 7.3; 8.2), “the abode of love of Vakreshvara and Pundarika” (Madhya 9.4), “He Who captivated the heart of Pundarika Vidyanidhi” (Antya 7.4); and Lochana Dasa at the beginning of the “Chaitanya-mangala” sings: “Joyfully I glorify Pundarika Vidyanidhi, for whom Mahaprabhu wept aloud” (Sutra-khanda, part 1, v. 23).

The life of Pundarika Vidyanidhi is a lesson in how to recognise a Vaishnava. Beneath the guise of a wealthy nobleman he kept a prema that, at a single verse about Krishna's mercy, scattered all his “luxury”; the Lord longed for him before seeing him, and wept, calling him father; Gadadhara, Radha Herself, received mantra from him — twice. Even his dispute over the starched cloth and Jagannatha's slaps are a lila in which the Lord showed how He caresses His dearest ones and taught us not to judge His servants. A Vaishnava cannot be recognised by appearance; he can be understood only by the mercy of the Vaishnavas.

When and where Pundarika Vidyanidhi left this world, the sources do not say: not one biography gives the day, the year or the place of his departure; nor is the day of his departure in our calendar.

1. One of the biographies, following the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (54), also calls him Pundarikaksha; so too Srila Bhaktisiddhanta reads this verse (*puṇḍarīkākṣo*), while our edition has *puṇḍarīkākhyaḥ*, “named Pundarika.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, in his commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 2.36–37), writes that Pundarika is also known as Premanidhi and Acharyanidhi; so one of the biographies too understands the list of Bengali devotees who carry the holy name to the world: “Acharyaratna, Acharyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Jagadananda, Damodara, Shankara, Vakreshvara” (CC, Antya 7.48). The “Charitamrita” itself does not explain who Acharyanidhi is; the name also stands in its other lists —

Madhya 10.82, 12.157; Antya 10.4, 10.120, 10.139.

2. The “other opinion” about Shuklambara is repeated after Srila Bhaktisiddhanta by one of the biographies as well.

3. So also two biographies. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (57) says: “A special manifestation of him is considered to be Sri Madhava Mishra, and his wife Ratnavati is declared by the wise to be Kirtida.” The words “his wife” may refer either to Pundarika or to Madhava Mishra; other biographies understand them in the second way, and in them Ratnavati is the mother of Gadadhara Pandita.

4. The name of the village is spelt differently — Meghal, Meghala, Mekhala; in substance it is one and the same place. The distances too are given differently: according to some, the Hathazari police district lies six kroshas north of Chattagrama, and the village one krosha east of it; according to others, the village lies two miles to the east of Hathazari, some twelve miles from the town to the north; according to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary, three kilometres east of Hata-hajari and eighteen north of Chattagrama. One of the biographies renders the ten kroshas to Chhanhara as “about twenty miles”; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gives thirty kilometres.

5. According to one of the biographies, Mukunda introduced Gadadhara only after Pundarika had come to himself after his ecstasy.

6. One of the biographies also mentions a hookah among these furnishings; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” does not.

7. How many verses were recited is told differently: according to some, the Bengali lines about Putana and two verses of the “Bhagavatam” (3.2.23 and 10.6.35), as in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”; according to others, only one verse (3.2.23), its number being given wrongly in one place (4.2.23); according to a third, a verse about Krishna's lila without further detail.

8. According to one of the biographies, Pundarika came to the Lord the very night that Gadadhara and Mukunda told Him of his arrival; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says simply “one night” (Madhya 7.123).

9. According to one account, it was Mahaprabhu Himself who advised Gadadhara to atone for the offence by initiation from Pundarika; according to others, Gadadhara decided this himself, and the Lord only joyfully approved. One of the biographies writes that Gadadhara told the Lord of Vidyanidhi's arrival together with Mukunda.

10. The verse number (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 12.3177) is given after this biography; the twelfth wave of that book is not yet in our translation, and the verse has not been checked.

11. One of the biographies refers here in different places to Madhya 1.255–256 and to “Madhya 9.255–256”; the correct reference is Madhya 1.255.

12. So says one of the biographies. In the “Charitamrita,” at the feast after the cleaning of Gundicha, Acharyanidhi is named among those seated with the Lord (Madhya 12.157); if this is Pundarika (see note 1), that is the source of the account.

13. When these pastimes took place the biographies say differently: according to one, at the time of the Ratha-yatra; according to another, at Jagannatha's Chandana-yatra, at Narendra-sarovara (Chandan-pukur). According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 8), the devotees of Gauda came to Nilachala that time for the Ratha-yatra, and the pastimes on the Narendra took place at the festival of the Chandana-yatra, on the day of their arrival; another water contest of Vidyanidhi and Svarupa, after the Ratha-yatra, is described by the “Charitamrita” — in Lake Indradyumna (Madhya 14.80). One of the biographies wrongly refers here to the “Charitamrita” (Antya 8.124); the verse is from the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.”

14. The words *rādhā-viraha-kātaraḥ* allow both readings: “afflicted by separation, like Radha” and “afflicted by separation from Radha.” The second is found in the rendering of the verse in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 2.36–37) and in one of the biographies; elsewhere the same biography says that the Lord called him so in the mood of Srimati Radharani; so our translation renders the verse. The biographies cite verses 54–57 as one block under the number 54.

15. One of the biographies gives the numbers Antya 10.183–184 for the last verses; in our edition these are Antya 10.180–181.